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Measuring Spiritual Maturity in Hearing God: An Affective Domain Taxonomy for Individual and Small-Group Internalization

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MEASURING SPIRITUAL MATURITY IN HEARING GOD:

An Affective Domain Taxonomy for Individual and Small-Group Internalization

Abstract. Consensus on measuring spiritual maturity has proven elusive because existing instruments conflate levels of affective internalization. Using Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia's affective-domain taxonomy, the article surveys six instruments, which cluster at Levels 1–3, none reliably measuring Levels 4–5; the Parable of the Sower supplies a parallel scriptural diagnostic. The central claim, advanced as a theoretical proposition awaiting the closing research program's multi-method validation, is that the clustering reflects a structural ceiling on self-report: above Level 3, social compliance and transformed character produce the same behavior, and the heart is opaque even to its owner (Jer 17:9), convergently supported by the Self–Other Knowledge Asymmetry model. The measurement problem therefore has no individual solution: self-report must be joined by the observing community, which can see above the ceiling and in which the highest levels are formed and discerned. The same argument governs individual and small-group maturity; falsifiable propositions close the program.

Keywords. spiritual formation; spiritual maturity; affective domain taxonomy; Krathwohl; discipleship assessment; small-group dynamics; self–other knowledge asymmetry; informant report; communal discernment

Introduction: The Measurement Problem

Churches want to know if they are making disciples. The instinct to measure is sound: as the axiom attributed to Peter Drucker states, "What gets measured, gets improved."[1] Yet after three decades of proliferating assessment instruments, no consensus has emerged on how to measure spiritual maturity. The landscape has multiple tools, with each grounded

[1] Peter Drucker, quoted in Jacob Drucker, "You Are What You Measure," *Forbes*, December 4, 2018.

in different theological assumptions, each measuring different constructs, each falling short in different ways. No unifying framework has been proposed to explain why consensus has proven so elusive.

This paper argues that the failure to achieve consensus is not primarily a failure of research methodology but of taxonomic clarity. Existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization, using tools built for surface-level behavioral compliance to measure deep character transformation. Using Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia's *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain* as a diagnostic framework,[2] this paper proposes that most instruments operate at only the first two levels (Receiving and Responding), while spiritual maturity requires measurement at the third through fifth (Valuing, Organization, and Characterization). As Paul Bramer observes, Christian education has tended "to focus on cognitive knowledge acquisition" while "Christian formation much more deliberately brings in the affective domain."[3] This paper develops that observation into a systematic measurement framework.

The paper surveys the existing instrument landscape, proposes level-specific measurement criteria, and extends the same taxonomy to the small-group scale, showing at each step why adequate measurement of the higher levels turns outward to the observing community. It illustrates the framework with a brief worked example, hearing and obeying God, whose fuller development across four theological traditions is reserved for a companion paper.

The thesis is this: no existing instrument is designed to reliably distinguish between a person who performs spiritual behaviors out of social compliance and a person whose character has been transformed by the indwelling Spirit. This is a theoretical and taxonomic argument, not an empirical one; its validation would require the kind of multi-method longitudinal study that lies beyond a single paper. Jesus identified this exact problem with the Pharisees: impeccable outward performance without interior transformation. The thesis concerns recognizing the observable results of the Holy

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[2] David R. Krathwohl, Benjamin S. Bloom, and Bertram B. Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook II: Affective Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1964).

[3] Paul D. G. Bramer, "Christian Formation: Tweaking the Paradigm," *Christian Education Journal*, Series 3, vol. 4, no. 2 (Fall 2007): 352–63.

Spirit's action in believers' hearts, not describing how the Spirit causes the transformation.

Stated most precisely, the argument of this paper is not merely that existing instruments measure the wrong levels, but that the levels they miss cannot, in principle, be measured the way the others are. Levels 1–3 can be captured by self-report because the construct, behavioral participation, conscious valuing, is available to introspection. Levels 4–5 cannot, because at that depth the same outward behavior is produced by compliance and by character alike, and because the transformed heart is partly hidden even from itself. This is not a gap that a better questionnaire will close; it is a ceiling. The individual measurement problem, in other words, has no individual solution. It is resolved only when measurement turns outward to the community, first as the multiple observers who can see what the self cannot report, and finally as the corporate body in which the deepest maturity is not merely observed but actually lives. This is why the present paper treats the individual and the small-group scales as one argument rather than two: the turn to communal observation that rescues individual measurement is the same turn that makes the group itself the higher unit of spiritual maturity. Separating the two would be to describe a problem and withhold its solution.

The Affective Domain and Spiritual Formation

In 1964, David Krathwohl, Benjamin Bloom, and Bertram Masia published the second volume of their landmark taxonomy of educational objectives, addressing the affective domain which is the realm of attitudes, values, emotions, and motivations.[4] While Bloom's cognitive taxonomy achieved wide adoption,[5] the affective taxonomy remained comparatively neglected. Yet it is the affective domain, not the cognitive, that most directly addresses the construct of spiritual maturity. Knowing the right answers (cognitive) is not the same as having the right values characterologically embedded (affective). The Pharisees scored perfectly on the cognitive domain; Jesus' critique was entirely about their affective status.

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[4] Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*.

[5] Benjamin S. Bloom et al., *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook I: Cognitive Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1956).

Two clarifications are necessary. First, the taxonomy is diagnostic rather than constitutive: it describes observable internalization structure without claiming to describe how the Spirit produces transformation. The Spirit's sovereign agency is assumed throughout; the taxonomy recognizes the results of that agency, not the mechanism. Second, all measurement here is measurement of effects, not causes.

The Five Levels of Internalization

Krathwohl's taxonomy is ordered according to the principle of internalization, the process by which an external value progressively becomes an internal, governing characteristic of the person.[6] The five levels, from lowest to highest, are:

Receiving. The person is aware of and willing to attend to certain ideas or phenomena. In spiritual terms, the person has heard the gospel, is exposed to Scripture, and is willing to listen. This is the floor of spiritual engagement.

Responding. The person actively engages, participates, complies, and follows through. They join a Bible study, complete assigned readings, and pray when prompted. Motivation is still largely external: social expectation, curriculum requirements, and accountability structures.

Valuing. The person has internalized the value sufficiently to pursue it without external prompting. They read Scripture not because a study guide requires it but because they want to. They serve from conviction rather than obligation. The critical shift is from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation.

Organization. The person integrates the value into a coherent system, resolving conflicts between competing values and arranging priorities. Faith informs vocation, relationships, finances, and daily decisions such that they are not compartmented but systematic.

Characterization. The value has controlled behavior for a sufficiently long time that it has become a characteristic lifestyle, "pervasive, consistent, and predictable."[7] The person does not deliberate about whether to act on the value; it is who they are.

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[6] Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 35–38.

[7] Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 165–85. Krathwohl describes Characterization as behavior that is "pervasive, consistent, and predictable."

One clarification governs everything that follows. The levels describe the internalization of particular values, not a global grade assigned to a person. Krathwohl's taxonomy is value-specific by construction, and spiritual formation is no different: the same person may exhibit deeply organized generosity (Level 4) alongside barely valued responses to criticism, status, or conflict (Level 2). Where this article speaks of a person "at" a level, the phrase is shorthand for the person's standing in the value domain under discussion, or at most for a modal center of gravity across domains. Adequate measurement is therefore domain-indexed measurement: a profile, not a score. The worked example later in this article deliberately examines a single domain, hearing and obeying God, for exactly this reason. Nor is the choice of domain arbitrary. When the disciples ask about the parable of the Sower, Jesus answers with a question of his own: "Do you not understand this parable? How then will you understand all the parables?" (Mark 4:13), presenting the fruit-bearing reception of the word as the paradigm on which everything else in his teaching depends. Romans 10:17 makes the same claim propositionally: faith itself comes from hearing. If the levels are to be demonstrated in one domain first, the domain Scripture treats as generative of all the others is the natural candidate: formation in every other value domain presupposes it, and, methodologically, hearing-and-obeying spans the full range from observable practice to interior discernment that a worked example must cover. Table 1 gathers the five levels into a single view (the construct each names, the data source suited to it, and the primary measurement threat at each level) as a map for everything that follows.

Table 1. The five levels of affective internalization: construct, suitable data source, and primary measurement threat at each level.

Level	**Construct**	**Suitable data source**	**Primary measurement threat**
Level 1: Receiving	Attention / openness	Self-report / behavior	Exposure mistaken for receptivity
Level 2: Responding	Participation	Behavioral records / self-report	Compliance mistaken for internalization
Level 3: Valuing	Internal motivation	Self + informant	Social desirability

Level 4: Organization	Resolution of competing values	Scenarios + observed decisions + informants	Hypothetical self-presentation
Level 5: Characterization	Stable cross-context character	Longitudinal multi-source observation	Observer bias / context sampling

Biblical Warrant for Progressive Internalization

Scripture consistently presents spiritual maturity as a process of progressive internalization that maps naturally onto Krathwohl's levels. The author of Hebrews rebukes readers who should be teachers but still need milk: "For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you need someone to teach you again the basic principles of the oracles of God. You need milk, not solid food, for everyone who lives on milk is unskilled in the word of righteousness, since he is a child. But solid food is for the mature, for those who have their powers of discernment trained by constant practice to distinguish good from evil" (Heb 5:12–14 ESV). The progression from milk to solid food, from unskilled to trained, from child to mature, from learner to teacher describes movement through levels of internalization. Ephesians 4:13–14 describes the telos as stability of character, or Krathwohl's Level 5, where behavior is "pervasive, consistent, and predictable."[8] The fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22–23) is the natural produce of Level 5 character where it is spontaneous, not manufactured.

The Parable of the Sower: A Theological Analogue

The Parable of the Sower (Matt 13:1–23; Mark 4:1–20; Luke 8:4–15) speaks with unusual directness to the concerns of this article, because Jesus diagnoses where and why the word fails to take root. Read through the lens of affective internalization, the four soils provide a suggestive theological analogue to different points at which reception and internalization may fail. A hermeneutical note is warranted: the parable's primary referent is the reception of the kingdom proclamation, not a developmental stage theory for ongoing sanctification. Its extension to the full arc of Christian formation is justified because the dynamics Jesus identifies (hardness of heart, rootlessness under pressure, competing value commitments) are not unique to initial response. The New Testament warning literature consistently applies these failure modes to established believers (cf.

[8] Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 176–80.

Heb 3–4; Rev 2–3).[9] Even so, the correspondence developed here should be read throughout as a pastoral-diagnostic heuristic that the parable's own logic invites but does not mandate; nothing in the measurement argument depends on the parable functioning as formal developmental theory. The four soils are not descriptions of personality types; they are descriptions of points of failure in internalization. Jesus' own interpretation names, for each soil, the point at which reception breaks down; these points align suggestively with the taxonomy's levels.

The path represents a failure prior to Level 1 (Receiving). The seed falls but never penetrates the surface: "When anyone hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it, the evil one comes and snatches away what has been sown in his heart" (Matt 13:19). The word is heard but not received; there is no willingness to attend, no crack in the surface through which the seed can enter. The person sits in the pew, hears the sermon, and remains entirely unaffected. No instrument can measure what was never received. This is pre-Level 1: the precondition of openness has not been met. It might be called Level 0, labeled hardheartedness.

The rocky ground represents a failure at the Level 2–3 transition (Responding without reaching Valuing). "As for what was sown on rocky ground, this is the one who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy, yet he has no root in himself, but endures only for a while, and when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately he falls away" (Matt 13:20–21). The critical diagnostic is "no root in himself." The response is externally sustained rather than internally rooted: when external supports dissolve, there is nothing internal to sustain the behavior. The rocky-ground hearer never makes the Responding–to–Valuing transition.

The thorny ground represents a failure at the Level 3–4 transition (Valuing without reaching Organization). "As for what was sown among thorns, this is the one who hears the word, but the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches choke the word, and it

[9] Craig L. Blomberg, *Interpreting the Parables*, 2nd ed. (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2012), esp. 13–44, where Blomberg argues that the parables are best read as unified narratives whose points of correspondence must be determined by the narrative logic of the whole rather than by allegorical assignment of meaning to individual details; and R. T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew*, New International Commentary on the New Testament (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2007), 504–22, where France's treatment of Matt 13 demonstrates how the Sower's diagnostic categories function as a framework for understanding ongoing receptivity to the word rather than a one-time response.

proves unfruitful" (Matt 13:22). This is the most subtle failure: the word has genuinely taken root, but the value system has not been organized with the kingdom as governing priority. Competing values such as financial security or social status choke it out. The thorny-ground hearer has values but no hierarchy.

The good soil represents successful internalization through Levels 4–5 (Organization to Characterization). "As for what was sown on good soil, this is the one who hears the word and understands it. He indeed bears fruit and yields, in one case a hundredfold, in another sixty, and in another thirty" (Matt 13:23). Luke's version adds a critical qualifier: the good soil represents those who "hearing the word, hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience" (Luke 8:15). Three elements define the good soil: the word is held fast (Organization), the heart is honest and good (interior matches exterior—no Pharisee gap), and fruit is borne with patience (Characterization). The varying yields suggest degrees within Level 5, consistent with Krathwohl's description of it as a continuum.

The parable thus provides a diagnostic framework that complements Krathwohl's taxonomy with theological specificity. Each soil identifies not only where internalization fails but why: the path fails because the heart is hard (no openness to receive); the rocky ground fails because the root system is shallow (no internal anchor for the value); the thorny ground fails because the value system is unorganized (competing commitments choke growth); and the good soil succeeds because the word has been fully internalized into the character of the person. Any instrument that claims to measure spiritual maturity must be able to distinguish between these four conditions, and as the instrument survey will observe, none currently can.

The Pharisee Problem: Measuring Levels 1–2 While Assuming Levels 4–5

Jesus' sustained critique of the Pharisees is, at its core, a critique of mistaking low-level behavioral compliance for high-level characterological transformation. "Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you clean the outside of the cup and the plate, but inside they are full of greed and self-indulgence" (Matt 23:25). The Pharisees would have scored perfectly on every Level 2 metric such as attendance, tithing, prayer frequency, Scripture knowledge, yet Jesus declared that tax collectors and prostitutes would enter the kingdom before them (Matt 21:31).

This is not merely a moral critique; it is a measurement critique. Every existing spiritual maturity instrument risks the same error when it relies primarily on self-reported behavioral frequency.

This lack of insight is a challenge for any church that cares about making real disciples. In Mark 4:13 Jesus makes this parable the criterion for understanding all the others: "Do you not understand this parable? How then will you understand all the parables?"—which implies that helping churches make real disciples will require a measurement approach equal to the heart's hiddenness.

Existing Instruments Through the Affective Domain Lens

Six instruments warrant examination, spanning academic psychology and church practice. When analyzed through the affective domain taxonomy, a pattern emerges: instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, with no instrument reliably measuring Levels 4–5.

Natural Church Development (Schwarz)

Christian Schwarz's Natural Church Development, implemented in over 75,000 churches globally, is probably the most widely used development approach.[10] It assesses eight quality characteristics of healthy churches through a survey of thirty leadership members. NCD functions at Levels 1–2, gauging organizational climate through self-report, but cannot determine whether members have internalized values beyond participation. Critics have raised transparency concerns about the research, to which Schwarz has responded.[11]

REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey (Hawkins and Parkinson)

The REVEAL study, originating at Willow Creek Community Church, surveyed over 250,000 individuals across more than 1,000 churches, placing respondents on a four-stage

[10] Christian A. Schwarz, *Natural Church Development: A Guide to Eight Essential Qualities of Healthy Churches* (Carol Stream, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 1996).

[11] Schwarz's response to methodological critics of the NCD research is available at http://www.ncd-international.org/public/research.html (accessed May 2026). Christian A. Schwarz, *God's Energy*, 3 vols. (NCD Media, 2021–2023).

continuum from "Exploring Christ" to "Christ-Centered."[12] Its key finding of that church activity does not predict or drive long-term spiritual growth is itself a demonstration of the affective-domain problem:[13] behavioral participation (Level 2) does not correlate with interior transformation (Levels 3–5). REVEAL operates at Levels 2–3, measuring self-reported practices and self-placed closeness to Christ. Wright criticized it for drawing longitudinal conclusions from cross-sectional data,[14] and Technical Report 3.0 acknowledged a respondent skew toward married, higher-income, more educated, disproportionately white which suggests significant self-selection bias.[15]

Discipleship Pathway Assessment (Waggoner/LifeWay)

The Discipleship Pathway Assessment, built on Brad Waggoner's 1991 doctoral research and refined through a 28-member expert-panel Delphi method from 2010 to 2012, measures eight "biblical signposts" through a sixty-eight-question self-report instrument.[16] The DPA operates at Levels 2–3, measuring reported frequency of spiritual behaviors and self-assessed attitudes. Vannoy's 2023 study found that practitioners rated it moderately useful (3.92/5) but identified critical weaknesses;[17] one church leader noted that the assessment "could almost show the church member the desired answer and without even realizing it nudge them to answer in the way they think they should answer."[18] This is the Level 2–3 indistinguishability problem: the instrument cannot differentiate genuine valuing from performing the right answer.

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[12] Greg L. Hawkins and Cally Parkinson, *Move: What 1,000 Churches Reveal about Spiritual Growth* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2011), 24–25. The 250,000 figure represents cumulative respondents across multiple rounds of data collection from 2007 to 2011.

[13] Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 10.

[14] Bradley Wright, review of Reveal: Where Are You?, by Greg L. Hawkins and Cally Parkinson, *Modern Reformation*, 2008.

[15] Nancy Scammacca Lewis, "REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey Technical Report 3.0" (2012).

[16] Chandler Keith Vannoy, "Measuring the Usefulness of the Discipleship Pathway Assessment in the Local Church" (DEdMin project, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2023), 41–45.

[17] Vannoy, "Measuring the Usefulness," 64.

[18] Vannoy, "Measuring the Usefulness," 67.

Faith Maturity Scale (Benson, Donahue, and Erickson)

Developed at the Search Institute as part of the National Study of Protestant Congregations, the Faith Maturity Scale operationalizes faith as comprising vertical (relationship with God) and horizontal (commitment to serving others) dimensions and has been validated across 11,000 participants from six mainline and evangelical denominations.[19] The FMS is psychometrically stronger than the church-practice instruments and has a validated factor structure across denominations. It operates primarily at Level 3, measuring self-reported value commitment, and therefore remains constrained by its self-report methodology.

Spiritual Assessment Inventory (Hall and Edwards)

The SAI is unique among these instruments in attempting to measure relational quality with God through an object-relations framework.[20] Its five factors; Awareness of God, Realistic Acceptance, Disappointment, Grandiosity, and Instability intend to operate at Levels 3–4, assessing not behavioral frequency but the quality and maturity of the person's relational orientation toward God. Critically, the SAI includes an Impression Management subscale to detect socially desirable responding, and is the only instrument in this survey that even attempts to address the self-report validity problem.[21] Its limitation is its grounding in psychoanalytic theory, which may not translate across all theological traditions.

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[19] Peter L. Benson, Michael J. Donahue, and Joseph A. Erickson, "The Faith Maturity Scale: Conceptualization, Measurement, and Empirical Validation," in *Research in the Social Scientific Study of Religion*, vol. 5, ed. Monty L. Lynn and David O. Moberg (Greenwich, CT: JAI Press, 1993), 6–8. The study sampled 11,000 participants from six mainline and evangelical denominations: Christian Church (Disciples of Christ), Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, Presbyterian Church (USA), United Church of Christ, United Methodist Church, and Southern Baptist Convention.

[20] Todd W. Hall and Keith J. Edwards, "The Spiritual Assessment Inventory: A Theistic Model and Measure for Assessing Spiritual Development," *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 41, no. 2 (2002): 341–57.

[21] Hall and Edwards, "Spiritual Assessment Inventory," 349–51. The Impression Management subscale consists of items designed to identify respondents presenting an unrealistically positive spiritual self-image.

Fowler's Stages of Faith

James Fowler's developmental stage model is the only framework in this survey that even claims the highest levels: Stages 5 and 6 describe a deeply characterological transformation.[22] The claim, however, has outrun its validation: Parker's review concluded that only the "broad contours" of the theory enjoy adequate empirical support, the invariant stage sequence has never been tested longitudinally, and Stage 6 is essentially aspirational.[23] The clinical-interview method is impractical for church use, short-form scales lose the construct, and the model's Kantian presuppositions (the form of faith analyzed apart from its Object) limit its usefulness for communities whose faith comes by hearing (Rom 10:17).[24]

Summary: The Clustering Problem

When analyzed through the affective-domain taxonomy, a clear pattern emerges. Hill and Pargament's observation that religion and spirituality are typically measured by "global indices that do not specify how or why religion and spirituality affect health" applies equally to spiritual maturity.[25] The instruments cluster at Levels 2–3; none reliably measures Level 5. The only one that even attempts to detect deception is the SAI with its

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[22] James W. Fowler, *Stages of Faith: The Psychology of Human Development and the Quest for Meaning* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1981), 197–211. Stage 5 (Conjunctive Faith) involves integration of opposites and openness to paradox; Stage 6 (Universalizing Faith) involves selfless devotion to transforming social conditions.

[23] Stephen Parker, "Research in Fowler's Faith Development Theory: A Review Article," *Review of Religious Research* 51, no. 3 (2010): 244–47. Parker notes that no published longitudinal study has tracked individuals through the predicted stage sequence.

[24] The reference is to Fowler's structural-developmental method, inherited from Piaget and Kohlberg and through them from Kant: the *form* of faith is analyzed apart from its *content* (so that a single "stage" may describe faith in any object or none), the knowing subject is held to *construct* its world rather than receive it, and maturity is figured as movement toward an autonomous, "universalizing" self that has critically moved beyond received tradition (the Stage 4 relocation of authority into the self; Stages 5–6). For a community whose faith is defined by its Object and comes by hearing (Rom. 10:17), a scheme that brackets content and prizes autonomy measures something other than maturity in hearing and obeying God. See Fowler, *Stages of Faith*; the neo-Kantian lineage runs through Piaget's genetic epistemology and Kohlberg's appropriation of Kantian universalizability.

[25] Peter C. Hill and Kenneth I. Pargament, "Advances in the Conceptualization and Measurement of Religion and Spirituality: Implications for Physical and Mental Health Research," *American Psychologist* 58, no. 1 (2003): 64.

Impression Management subscale. This clustering is not coincidental: it reflects the fundamental constraint of self-report instrumentation.

Why Higher Levels Resist Self-Report Measurement

Three structural problems explain why Levels 3–5 resist conventional self-report methodology. The difficulty, to speak precisely, is one of construct validity rather than reliability: a self-report measure can be highly internally consistent and temporally stable while measuring socially desirable spiritual behavior rather than transformed character. The central psychometric problem, in other words, is not that existing instruments are necessarily unreliable, but that reliable measurement of spiritual practices or conscious values does not establish valid measurement of characterological internalization. Four claims of differing epistemic standing run through what follows, and they should be kept distinct: that self-report is vulnerable to particular biases is documented; that informants add incremental information is documented; that these problems should become more serious at higher levels of spiritual internalization is this article's theoretical proposal; and how large these effects prove to be in spiritual-maturity assessment is a still-unanswered empirical question, the one the closing research program is designed to answer.

The Indistinguishability Problem

Levels 2 and 5 produce identical behavioral outputs. The person who serves out of social expectation and the person who serves from transformed character both report "I serve regularly." A person performing spiritual behaviors out of compliance (Level 2) and a person whose character has been transformed (Level 5) will yield identical scores on any instrument measuring behavioral frequency. This is the fundamental measurement wall.

The Self-Knowledge Problem

Genuine Characterization (Level 5) may be less self-aware than lower levels because the value has become automatic. The most spiritually mature person may actually underreport because their behavior feels unremarkable to them. Conversely, someone at Level 2 may overreport because they are performing for an audience, including themselves. This parallels Kruger and Dunning's finding that those least competent are

most confident in their self-assessments.[26] In the spiritual domain, those most mature are most aware of their deficiency. Paul, near the end of his life, declared, "Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost" (1 Tim 1:15), present tense, not past.

The Theological Problem

Jeremiah 17:9 is not merely a proof-text but a genuine epistemological claim about the limits of introspection. Its immediate context is a covenant-unfaithfulness indictment, but its claim about the opacity of the human heart extends further, as Paul's parallel in Romans 7 confirms: "I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate" (Rom 7:15). James warns that self-deception is a structural temptation of the spiritual life (Jas 1:22, 26), and John names self-justifying self-assessment as a mark of the person who has not yet internalized the light (1 John 1:8). The pattern is consistent: introspective self-report is limited not because it is worthless but because it meets a ceiling. If the heart is opaque even to its owner, self-report instruments measure the person's theory of themselves, not their actual inner state: "the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart" (1 Sam 16:7). The implication is not that self-report should be abandoned; confession, testimony, and pastoral dialogue all depend on it, and the SAI's Impression Management subscale shows it can be refined to detect socially desirable responding. The implication is that its validity ceiling falls below the level of characterological transformation.

The Empirical Convergence: Self–Other Knowledge Asymmetry

These three problems are theological and conceptual. The same asymmetry between what a person can report about themselves and what others can observe has been documented empirically in personality psychology, influentially in Simine Vazire's Self–Other Knowledge Asymmetry (SOKA) model.[27] Vazire's 2010 research compares self-ratings,

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[26] Justin Kruger and David Dunning, "Unskilled and Unaware of It: How Difficulties in Recognizing One's Own Incompetence Lead to Inflated Self-Assessments," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 77, no. 6 (1999): 1121.

[27] Simine Vazire, "Who Knows What About a Person? The Self–Other Knowledge Asymmetry (SOKA) Model," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 98, no. 2 (2010): 281–300.

informant ratings by friends and acquaintances, and behavioral criteria, and finds that the relative accuracy of each source depends on two properties of the trait being measured: its observability (how visible it is in behavior) and its evaluativeness (how ego-threatening or socially desirable it is). Self-reports are most valid for traits low in observability and low in evaluativeness which are internal states such as anxiety or subjective contentment that others cannot easily see and that carry little threat to self-image. Informant reports become more valid, and self-reports less so, precisely as traits become more behaviorally visible and more evaluative and enter the domain in which ego-defense distorts self-perception. As Vazire and Carlson summarize the wider literature, others sometimes know us better than we know ourselves.[28] The strongest prediction of all comes from combining perspectives.

This framework converges with notable precision onto the affective-domain levels; the convergence is offered as independent corroboration from a secular research literature, not as confirmation of the theological claim. The asymmetry, moreover, cuts both ways: the model itself finds that the self retains privileged access to low-observability interior experience, while others see evaluative, visible traits more accurately. What follows is therefore not a transfer of authority from self to observers but a multi-method, multi-informant design in which each source contributes what it alone sees; observer reports, no less than self-reports, carry their own distortions of halo, loyalty, and limited access. The constructs measured at Levels 1–3 (participation, conscious desire, stated value) are relatively low in evaluativeness and accessible to introspection; self-report serves them adequately, which is exactly why existing instruments succeed there. The constructs at Levels 4–5 (whether faith genuinely governs competing priorities, whether obedience has become characterological) are both highly evaluative (no one wishes to see themselves as a hypocrite) and most fully expressed in observable behavior over time. These are the conditions under which the SOKA literature predicts self-report will be weakest and informant observation strongest, and Connelly and Ones's meta-analysis of observer ratings confirms it, finding that informants' assessments of personality predict behavioral

[28] Simine Vazire and Erika N. Carlson, "Others Sometimes Know Us Better Than We Know Ourselves," *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 20, no. 2 (2011): 104–8.

and performance outcomes as well as, and often better than, self-reports.[29] The clinical literature on personality disorders reaches the same conclusion from the opposite direction: individuals routinely under-detect their own interpersonal dysfunction, informants identify maladaptive patterns the person cannot fully see, and combining sources improves diagnosis.[30] The field has accordingly moved away from the question "which source is true?" toward an integration of a mix of different sources for different criteria, the same move this paper urges for spiritual measurement. The goal, accordingly, is not to identify the single true reporter but to study theoretically meaningful convergence and divergence among sources. This is a governing methodological principle of everything that follows: a gap between self-report and informant report is treated as data rather than noise, and the predicted pattern of where agreement breaks down (Proposition 2) is the proposed ceiling's empirical signature. Jeremiah's claim that the heart is opaque to its owner is thus not a piece of pre-modern pessimism that empirical psychology has outgrown. The SOKA literature provides an empirical analogue to the epistemological limitation identified theologically in these texts, an analogue that also supplies a measurement structure: above the threshold where constructs become evaluative and behaviorally expressed, the self is not the best-placed witness to itself, and informant input is needed.

Proposed Criteria for Measurement at Each Affective Level

Rather than proposing a single replacement instrument, this paper presents level-specific criteria for what constitutes adequate measurement at each stage of internalization.

Levels 1–2: Receiving and Responding

Conventional metrics work at these levels. Attendance, participation frequency, completion of assigned readings, group attendance, and giving records are adequate

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[29] Brian S. Connelly and Deniz S. Ones, "An Other Perspective on Personality: Meta-Analytic Integration of Observers' Accuracy and Predictive Validity," *Psychological Bulletin* 136, no. 6 (2010): 1092–1122.

[30] Thomas F. Oltmanns and Eric Turkheimer, "Person Perception and Personality Pathology," *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 18, no. 1 (2009): 32–36; E. David Klonsky, Thomas F. Oltmanns, and Eric Turkheimer, "Informant-Reports of Personality Disorder: Relation to Self-Reports and Future Research Directions," *Clinical Psychology: Science and Practice* 9, no. 3 (2002): 300–311.

because the behaviors are external and verifiable. Self-report is sufficient because the construct being measured (behavioral participation) matches the method (behavioral self-report). Churches already measure these levels well. The problem is not measurement failure at Levels 1–2 but the assumption that these metrics indicate transformation at Levels 3–5.

Level 3: Valuing

Measurement at Level 3 requires motivation-sensitive items, not "Do you read the Bible?" but "When you miss Bible reading for a week, what do you experience?" Reverse-scored items become critical, as do impression management subscales following the SAI model. Behavioral consistency checks, whether reported values match across different life domains, can help distinguish genuine valuing from socially conditioned reporting. This requires observation by people who know the person and can assess actual behaviors. The most valid indicator of genuine Level 3 is what the person does when no one is watching and nothing is required.

The measurement challenge at this level is therefore not item design alone but source design. Motivation-sensitive and reverse-scored items sharpen self-report, and an impression-management subscale on the SAI model can flag socially desirable responding; but the SOKA findings imply a limit on even a well-built Level 3 self-report, because valuing is already partly evaluative. The decisive evidence is convergence: does the person's self-described valuing match what an informant who knows them well, a spouse, a small-group leader, a close friend, would independently report about where their discretionary time, attention, and money actually go? A practical Level 3 protocol pairs a refined self-report with a brief parallel-form informant rating on the same items and treats the gap between them as data rather than noise. Two cautions attend this: informants must be genuinely close, since acquaintance ratings add little at this depth, and the instrument must guard against a new bias, informants who share the person's community may unconsciously rate toward the community's stated norms rather than the person's observed behavior.

Level 4: Organization

Measurement at Level 4 requires scenario-based assessment that represents value conflicts and asks how the person resolves them. Not "Do you value generosity?" but "When generosity conflicts with financial security for your family, how do you navigate

that?" This moves beyond the SAI's relational quality approach toward concrete dilemmas. Multi-source data becomes essential: does the person's self-report match what their small group leader, spouse, or coworker would say?

The central measurement challenge at Level 4 is that value-conflict resolution is largely invisible until a real conflict occurs, and self-reported answers to hypothetical dilemmas are themselves subject to the impression-management problem. Two supplements are required. First, scenario items should be anchored to the person's actual recent decisions ("Describe the last time generosity and family security genuinely competed for you, and what you did") rather than to abstract hypotheticals, which elicit a theory of self rather than behavior. Second, and more importantly, Level 4 requires triangulation: the person's account of how they integrate competing commitments is set beside the accounts of those who watched them decide. The validity of this multi-source method depends on observer selection, observers must have witnessed the person under actual pressure, not merely in the group's curated settings, and on a structured protocol that asks observers about specific behaviors rather than global impressions, the move the SOKA research shows most improves informant accuracy.

Level 5: Characterization

Level 5 may be fundamentally unmeasurable by the individual alone. Krathwohl described this level as requiring observation of behavior that is "pervasive, consistent, and predictable" over time.[31] The theological parallel is that fruit is observed by others, not self-certified: "You will recognize them by their fruits" (Matt 7:16). Measurement at this level requires longitudinal pastoral observation, community corroboration, and behavioral consistency across contexts. A complete instrument for spiritual maturity would need to be a multi-method, longitudinal, multi-source assessment system rather than a single survey.

Because Level 5 is defined by behavior that is "pervasive, consistent, and predictable" over time, its measurement challenge is irreducibly longitudinal and irreducibly communal: no cross-sectional instrument and no single observer can establish it. Adequate measurement at this level requires a longitudinal pastoral-observation protocol, repeated structured observation by several people who know the person across multiple

[31] Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 165–85.

contexts (home, work, conflict, crisis) over a sustained period, corroborated by the person's own testimony but not governed by it. This is demanding, and three challenges confront this approach. It is costly, requiring trained observers and time most congregations do not budget. It is vulnerable to communal bias, since a community invested in a person's maturity may see what it hopes to see; the safeguard is to seek observers across contexts who do not share the same investment. And it is, finally, never complete: "the LORD sees not as man sees" (1 Sam 16:7), and even the best communal observation reports *the fruit, not the root*. These limits are not a reason to abandon Level 5 measurement but a reason to locate it where it can actually occur, inside a community that watches over time, rather than inside a survey that cannot.

A Worked Example: The Taxonomy Applied to Hearing and Obeying God

To show that the taxonomy is generative and not merely descriptive, consider its application, in the domain-indexed sense described above, to one specific domain of spiritual maturity: hearing and obeying God. The same five levels organize this domain cleanly. At Receiving, the person becomes aware that God communicates and is willing to attend; at Responding, they engage the means of grace, Scripture, prayer, corporate worship, though the practices can still feel mechanical; at Valuing, engagement shifts from external discipline to internal desire ("Oh how I love your law!" Ps 119:97); at Organization, the person integrates the whole of life around hearing and obeying ("whatever you do, do all to the glory of God," 1 Cor 10:31); and at Characterization, hearing and obeying is no longer something the person does but who they are ("It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me," Gal 2:20).

This application also yields an observation about resources: the practices that move a person through these levels are distributed across the church's major streams: the Reformed emphasis on the authority of Scripture, the evangelical emphasis on personal engagement, the charismatic emphasis on present-tense discernment of the Spirit's voice, and the contemplative emphasis on receptive union. Different Christian traditions may thus contribute distinctive formative resources relevant to different dimensions or levels

of internalization.[32] Whether these streams carry characteristic strengths and limits at particular levels, and how they integrate, is a substantial question in its own right, deferred to a companion manuscript; nothing in the present argument depends on it.

The payoff for measurement stands on the narrower observation alone: if the resources of mature hearing-and-obeying are distributed across streams, then observers formed within a single stream will each see only part of the arc, and discerning the highest levels requires observers whose competencies are themselves distributed, which is to say, it requires the body. The worked example thus returns to the paper's central claim: the deepest maturity is both produced and recognized communally.

Small-Group Spiritual Maturity: A Parallel Taxonomy

A group has emergent properties that are not merely the average of individual scores. Five individually mature believers can form a spiritually immature group, one that avoids conflict, stays superficial, and functions as a social club with prayer appended. The New Testament envisions spiritual maturity as inherently communal: "The body does not consist of one member but of many" (1 Cor 12:14), and the more than fifty "one another" commands are, by definition, group-level indicators of maturity.[33] The body metaphor (1 Cor 12:14–26) and the Acts 13:1–3 paradigm of corporate discernment both show that groups exhibit emergent spiritual properties not reducible to the sum of their members' scores, a conclusion Levi and Askay's group-dynamics research independently supports.

Drawing on Levi and Askay's *Group Dynamics for Teams*,[34] this section proposes a five-level small-group taxonomy parallel to Krathwohl's individual taxonomy, incorporating

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[32] Richard J. Foster, *Streams of Living Water: Celebrating the Great Traditions of Christian Faith* (San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 1998); the present argument differs in mapping the traditions onto levels of internalization rather than thematically.

[33] The exact count depends on textual variants and how phrases are grouped. Sometimes cited as fifty-nine distinct commands. See, e.g., Jerry Bridges, *True Community: The Biblical Practice of Koinonia* (Colorado Springs: NavPress, 2012), 175–80.

[34] Daniel Levi and David A. Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 6th ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE, 2021).

insights from Tuckman's stage model,[35] group norm theory, research on social loafing, and groupthink analysis.

Level 1: Assembling (Parallel to Receiving)

The group gathers with nominal agreement on purpose. Leadership is entirely centralized; the leader selects content, facilitates discussion, and initiates prayer. If the leader is absent, the group cancels or defaults to socializing. Members are recipients, not contributors, to the discernment process. Measurement is straightforward: attendance consistency, whether the group opens a Bible or prays. Levi's research emphasizes that norms established in these early meetings persist throughout the group's life.[36] A group that begins with surface-level sharing establishes a norm of surface-level interaction that becomes difficult to break.

Level 2: Interacting (Parallel to Responding)

Members actively engage with each other rather than only with the leader. Discussion becomes dialogical. Tuckman's storming phase often begins here as genuine opinions surface. How the group handles its first real disagreement is one of the most consequential moments in its life. Levi's research shows that groups that suppress conflict at this stage establish avoidance norms that permanently freeze the group.[37] Social loafing becomes visible: a few members carry the discussion while others observe.[38] Measurement should track participation distribution, not just average engagement.

Level 3: Trusting (Parallel to Valuing)

The group develops genuine relational trust, enabling what Edmondson terms psychological safety, the shared belief that the group is safe for interpersonal risk-taking,

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[35] Bruce W. Tuckman and Mary Ann C. Jensen, "Stages of Small Group Development Revisited," *Group and Organizational Studies* 2, no. 4 (1977): 419–27.

[36] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

[37] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48. Levi distinguishes task conflict (disagreement about work content), process conflict (disagreement about logistics and procedures), and relationship conflict (personal friction).

[38] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 105–18.

which Levi applies directly to small-group development.[39] Members share honest struggles, doubts, and failures unprompted by the curriculum. The critical distinction, drawn from group-norm theory, is between performative trust (the stated norm is "we're vulnerable here" while the behavioral norm is carefully managed self-disclosure) and normative trust (the behavioral norm genuinely supports disclosure and challenge).[40] The group that performs vulnerability looks identical to the group that has internalized it, the same indistinguishability problem that plagues individual measurement. Three pathologies threaten here: emotional enmeshment, theological gatekeeping that quenches the Spirit, and groupthink.[41]

Level 4: Integrating (Parallel to Organization)

The group develops shared mental models, Levi's term for collective understanding of both task and relational processes.[42] Leadership is distributed: multiple members can facilitate, initiate care, and shepherd others.[43] Levi's leadership absence test applies: if the designated leader is absent for two weeks, does the group function at the same level? If yes, the discernment culture is embedded in the group, not housed in one person. The group demonstrates team reflexivity, the ability to evaluate and improve its own processes.[44] Conflict is primarily process conflict (disagreements about how to work) resolved through negotiated norms rather than leader intervention.[45] Bonhoeffer's vision of authentic Christian community becomes operational.[46]

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[39] Amy C. Edmondson, "Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams," *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44, no. 2 (1999): 350–51. Levi applies this concept to small-group development in Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74.

[40] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

[41] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

[42] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52.

[43] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 197–215.

[44] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 153–55.

[45] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48.

[46] Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Life Together*, trans. John W. Doberstein (New York: Harper & Row, 1954), 26–30. Bonhoeffer warns that community built on human ideals rather than divine reality inevitably becomes a source of disillusionment.

Level 5: Reproducing (Parallel to Characterization)

The group's culture has become so deeply internalized that it reproduces in new contexts. Members carry the group's DNA into other relationships and settings, and the group sends members out to lead new groups without experiencing this as a loss; new members are formed by the culture rather than destabilizing it. This is Levi's organizational learning transfer, practices and culture successfully replicated beyond the original team.[47] The ultimate test: can a member plant a new group elsewhere and reproduce the culture of corporate discernment? The paradigm is Acts 13:1–3, where the Antioch church heard God together and obeyed at great cost, releasing its best leaders and producing the Gentile mission that changed history.

The Parable of the Sower Applied to Group Soil

The Parable of the Sower applies to groups as powerfully as to individuals, because a group develops a collective "soil condition", a shared receptivity to God's word that is a property of the relational system, not merely of its members. A group of individually receptive people can form a collectively hard path; a group with strong relational infrastructure can become good soil even for members whose individual receptivity is shallow. The group's soil is its culture.

The path group has assembled (Level 0), but its culture prevents the word from penetrating. The meeting format itself functions as hardened ground: content is consumed passively, discussion stays abstract, and the word bounces off the group's surface without entering its relational life. The leader teaches; members nod; relationships remain untouched, and everyone goes home unchanged. Levi's norm research explains the mechanism: if the earliest meetings establish a norm of surface-level interaction, that norm hardens like a path under foot traffic,[48] snatching the word away before it can germinate.

The rocky-ground group has reached Level 1/2 and is marked by enthusiasm without depth. Such groups often form around a shared experience such as a retreat, a crisis, a charismatic leader and generate intense early connection; members report feeling deeply

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[47] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58.

[48] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

known, and the group "immediately receives the word with joy." But the root system is shallow because the group's trust is performative rather than normative: the stated norm is vulnerability, while the behavioral norm is carefully managed self-disclosure that avoids genuine cost.[49] When tribulation comes—a painful conflict, a moral failure, a leader transition—the group has no root in itself and lacks the organizational depth (Level 4) to survive disruption.

The thorny-ground group has genuine trust (Level 2/3 transition) but has not organized its collective life around the word's priorities (Level 4).[50] The thorny-ground group bears little fruit because it has never subordinated its competing values, comfort, harmony, and self-preservation to the word's demand for costly obedience. These groups can persist for years, meeting faithfully, sharing warmly, and producing little of kingdom consequence.

The good-soil group has integrated the word into its collective character (Levels 4–5). Its culture—norms, relational patterns, shared practices has been so thoroughly shaped by the Word that fruit production is organic rather than programmatic. The varying yields, thirty, sixty, a hundredfold apply to groups as well: not every good-soil group produces the same quantity, but every good-soil group produces fruit with patience. Luke's qualifier is essential: "Hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience" (Luke 8:15). The honest heart at the group level is normative trust, the group's behavior matches its stated values, and patience is the willingness to sustain corporate discernment through the corporate dark night that strips the group of felt confirmation and leaves it dependent on nothing but the word and the Spirit.

The Sower parable thus gives church leaders a diagnostic question of a kind no survey asks: What kind of soil is this group. Is the word bouncing off the surface of polite discussion (path), enthusiastically received but rootless (rocky), choked by competing commitments and the comfort of the status quo (thorns), or so integrated into the group's culture that fruit is the natural, patient result (good soil)? A trained observer can answer in three meetings. No survey instrument can answer it at all.

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[49] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Edmondson, "Psychological Safety," 350–83.

[50] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

Hearing and Obeying God Together: The Small-Group Taxonomy Applied

The fundamental shift from individual to group hearing is this: the Spirit distributes hearing across the body. One member receives a word, another tests it, another sees how to apply it, and another has the courage to act on it. No single person carries the full signal. "To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good" (1 Cor 12:7).

Levels 1–2: From Consuming to Processing Together

At Level 1, hearing God is mediated by the leader. The leader teaches; members listen. Prayer requests are informational rather than discernment-oriented. At Level 2, the group begins processing together. Members build on each other's contributions. The Spirit distributes to each member (1 Cor 14:26), and what moves a group forward is the leader asking genuine questions—not curriculum questions they already know the answers to.

Level 3: Developing Collective Discernment

Trust enables the group to move from discussing God's Word to discerning God's voice together. Members bring real decisions to the group for genuine input, not just prayer support.[51] Corporate listening prayer becomes regular: the group prays about a specific question and then shares what they received, noting convergences and exploring divergences.[52]

Level 4: Operating as a Discerning Body

The group has developed an integrated practice of corporate hearing and obeying. Individual members' hearing is naturally submitted to the group for testing; the group's collective discernment naturally informs individual decisions.[53] The group also hears God about itself, its own health, blind spots, and calling.[54] Obedience has become corporate: the group acts together, not just individually. Foster's discussion of the corporate

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[51] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Edmondson, "Psychological Safety," 350–83.

[52] Dallas Willard, *Hearing God: Developing a Conversational Relationship with God* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2012), 67–95.

[53] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52.

[54] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 153–55.

Discipline of Guidance offers several concrete models of what such collective hearing and obedience can look like in practice.[55]

Level 5: The Group's Hearing Culture Multiplies

Former members lead new groups that exhibit the same culture, not by following a manual, but by having been formed by the original group's culture.[56] Members instinctively create conditions for honest dialogue, prayerful discernment, and courageous obedience in every context they enter. The group's culture has become portable.

From the Hidden Heart to the Observing Body: The Communal Turn

The two scales examined in this paper are often treated as separate subjects where individual formation is on one side and group health on the other. An instrument built for one is rarely thought to bear on the other. The taxonomy reveals them to be two ends of a single argument. The individual analysis establishes a problem it cannot, by itself, solve: above Level 3, self-report meets a ceiling, and the construct of interest ceases to be visible to self-report alone and requires convergent observer testimony over time. The small-group analysis supplies precisely what the individual analysis lacks, an observing community, and in doing so discloses something the individual frame could not show: that the highest levels of maturity are not merely better seen in community but partly constituted by it.

The community performs two distinct offices here, and they should not be confused. First, it is the instrument: the multiple, longitudinal, cross-context observers whose convergent testimony can register what no self-report can reach. This is the methodological office, and it is what the SOKA literature underwrites, the body as a many-membered informant panel. Second, the community is the locus: the place where Level 4–5 maturity in fact resides. "To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good" (1 Cor 12:7); the body hears what no member hears alone, and at Antioch it was the gathered church, not an individual, that heard and obeyed at the cost of

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[55] Richard J. Foster, *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1978), 150–59.

[56] Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58.

its best leaders (Acts 13:1–3). The first office makes the community the measurer; the second makes it, increasingly, the thing measured.

That the same Parable of the Sower serves diagnostically at both scales is itself suggestive. Individual hearts develop soil conditions; groups develop collective soil cultures; the failure modes hardness, rootlessness, competing values, fruitful depth recur because the word meets the same kinds of resistance whether the soil is a person or a people. A heuristic that serves at both scales is at least consistent with a single internalization dynamic operating at two levels of organizational complexity.

Implications and Conclusion

This paper has argued that the failure to achieve consensus on measuring spiritual maturity stems from a taxonomic failure: existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization. Krathwohl's taxonomy provides a diagnostic framework to explain why instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, why Levels 4–5 resist conventional measurement, and what adequate measurement would require at each level. The framework applies at both the individual and small-group scales, revealing the same internalization dynamics at each level of organizational complexity.

The deeper contribution, however, lies one step beyond the taxonomy. The taxonomy explains why instruments fail; the turn to communal observation explains what to do about it. The central claim of this paper is that measurement of the highest levels of spiritual maturity is not a task better self-report alone can accomplish; it requires the observing community as the indispensable additional informant, completing rather than replacing the person's own testimony. How a congregation forms and sustains that observing body in practice by raising up the integrating leaders who shepherd the formation and providing the curriculum that carries a group across the levels is the subject of a companion paper, as the integration of the traditions is of another.

Several practical implications follow. First, churches should stop treating any single instrument as a comprehensive measure of maturity; each has a valid operating range within the taxonomy, and none covers the full spectrum. Second, churches should match the instrument to the affective level they need to assess. Table 1 is the map: existing tools serve Levels 1–2; Level 3 requires redesign around motivation rather than frequency; Levels 4–5 require moving beyond surveys altogether.

Third, the small-group taxonomy offers a practical diagnostic framework that requires no survey at all. A church leader can assess group maturity through three observable indicators drawn from group dynamics research: the leadership absence test (does the group function when the leader is absent?), the conflict handling diagnostic (how does the group process disagreement?), and the participation distribution metric (how broadly is engagement shared?). These behavioral observations provide information unavailable to self-report and are potentially more valid than self-report data as indicators of the higher levels of internalization. Each indicator can be operationalized as a structured observation protocol requiring only a trained observer and three to six months of field observation; the closing propositions predict, but do not yet demonstrate, that these indicators will contribute incremental validity beyond self-report for assessing maturity above Level 3.

The Parable of the Sower provides an additional diagnostic lens, offered again as pastoral heuristic rather than exegesis, and perhaps the most pastorally accessible of all. Jesus' four soils map suggestively onto the internalization levels: the hard path (failed Receiving), the rocky ground (Responding without Valuing), the thorny ground (Valuing without Organization), and the good soil (Organization through Characterization). This framework applies at both the individual and small-group scales: individual hearts develop soil conditions, and groups develop collective soil cultures shaped by their relational norms. A pastor who can identify the soil condition at either scale has diagnosed not only the current level but the specific barrier preventing further growth.

Fourth, the scope of this paper's contribution should be stated plainly. The taxonomic framework and level-specific criteria presented here constitute Phase 1 of a multi-stage research program: **Phase 1** establishes the diagnostic framework: why instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, what adequate measurement requires at each level (Table 1), and the behavioral observation protocol above. **Phase 2** and beyond would develop and pilot the instruments Table 1 calls for at each level, from motivation-sensitive items to the longitudinal pastoral-observation protocol. The paper does not claim to have solved the measurement problem; it claims to have diagnosed it precisely enough to make **Phase 2+** tractable.

Toward Phase 2: Testable Propositions

The program can be stated as falsifiable propositions, a discipline this literature has sometimes lacked: Fowler's stage sequence, proposed in 1981, has never been tested by a

published longitudinal study, and the present framework should not be permitted the same indefinite deferral.

Proposition 1 (incremental validity). Informant reports will demonstrate incremental validity beyond self-report in predicting behavioral criteria of internalization: persistence of practice under adverse conditions, costly obedience, and unprompted service observed across settings.

Proposition 2 (the ceiling, made falsifiable). Self–informant agreement will decline as the taxonomic level of the target construct rises, with the steepest decline between Level 3 and Level 4 targets.

Proposition 3 (SOKA moderation). The decline predicted in Proposition 2 will be moderated by observability and evaluativeness, tracking the Self–Other Knowledge Asymmetry model's predictions when its trait dimensions are mapped onto level-diagnostic behaviors.

Proposition 4 (domain-specificity). Within-person variation in level across value domains will be substantial: sufficient that a single global maturity score misfits the data relative to a domain-indexed profile.

Proposition 5 (longitudinal criterion). Motivation-sensitive items combined with informant convergence will predict multi-year persistence and depth of practice better than frequency-based self-report, with the advantage increasing at higher levels.

Proposition 6 (discriminant power: the Pharisee problem, made falsifiable). Multi-method assessment will distinguish individuals with similar levels of reported spiritual practice but different patterns of motivation, value integration, and behavior under competing demands.

Proposition 7 (characterological stability). Indicators of Level 5 characterization will show greater temporal stability and cross-situational consistency than indicators of lower-level responding.

Proposition 8 (group-level emergence). Group-level maturity will predict emergent group processes beyond the aggregate spiritual-maturity scores of individual members.

Disconfirmation is specified in advance: if self-report tracks informant consensus and behavioral criteria equally well at Levels 4–5, the ceiling proposed here is falsified, and the communal turn loses its methodological, though not its theological, warrant.

These eight propositions are a starter set, not a boundary. The framework generates questions faster than one article can pursue them: how the integrating leaders who shepherd such groups are formed; what curriculum carries a group across the levels; what a congregation must become to be a home for groups doing this work; how the formative resources of the traditions integrate. Each is a study, or a companion article, in its own right; several of the companions have already been noted. The propositions above mark where the measurement claim itself stands falsifiable; the program around them is larger.

To ground these implications in pastoral practice, consider two composite illustrations. Both are illustrative constructions, not case reports, and they offer no evidence that the proposed diagnostic method has been validated; validation is precisely what the Phase 2 propositions are designed to test. They show only what the framework looks like in a pastor's hands. The first concerns individual spiritual direction. A directee presents as actively engaged: daily Scripture, small group, children's ministry, a reported closeness to God. The director asks a motivation-sensitive question: "When you missed your Scripture reading for ten days during last month's family crisis, what did you notice in yourself?" She pauses, then admits she felt relief rather than loss: the reading had become an obligation performed for self-image, not a desire genuinely internalized. That single response diagnoses a lack of Level 2–3 transition no self-report instrument would have detected. The second illustration concerns small-group assessment. A pastor applies the three-indicator protocol to two groups that score identically on the DPA. Over six months, Group A cancels when its leader is absent, two members carry ninety percent of discussion, and its first disagreement was redirected to a curriculum question; Group B functions at full depth without its leader, distributes contributions broadly, and worked through its first conflict in a forty-minute honest conversation that deepened trust. Group A is at Level 2, Group B at Level 4, a distinction the identical DPA scores concealed and three meetings of observation revealed.

The conclusion of this analysis is that spiritual maturity at its deepest levels is partially opaque to measurement by design. Observer reports are no direct window into the heart either; they register *the fruit, not the root*, and they do so over time and across contexts;

that is why the method proposed here is convergence among imperfect witnesses rather than the substitution of one oracle for another. The heart's hiddenness is not a bug in the system but a feature of human finitude before a transcendent God. "The LORD sees not as man sees" (1 Sam 16:7). This does not make measurement worthless—it makes it humble. The taxonomy presented here does not solve the measurement problem; it diagnoses why the problem exists, identifies what adequate measurement would require at each level, and names the specific barriers that prevent existing instruments from capturing the full depth of spiritual transformation. We can measure what we can measure, name what we cannot, and trust that the One who searches hearts knows what our instruments never will. Divergence among the witnesses, when it comes, is not the method failing; it is the method working: the discrepancies are data.

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